

Parietaria officinalis syn. *P. diffusa*
(Urticaceae)

Pellitory-of-the-Wall

Description Annual growing to 28 in (70 cm). Has deep green leaves, greenish flowers, and small dark seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, this plant is commonplace in southern countries, where it is found on walls and in dry stony sites. It is gathered in summer when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Pellitory-of-the-wall contains flavonoids and tannins.

History & Folklore For more than 2,000 years, pellitory-of-the-wall has been valued as a diuretic, as a soother of chronic coughs, and as a balm for wounds and burns.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pellitory-of-the-wall is chiefly employed as a diuretic, demulcent, and stone-preventing herb. In European herbal medicine, it is regarded as having a restorative action on the kidneys, supporting and strengthening their function. It has been prescribed for conditions such as nephritis, pyelitis (inflammation of the kidney), kidney stones, renal colic (pain caused by kidney stones), cystitis, and edema (fluid retention). It is also occasionally taken as a laxative.

Caution Do not take if suffering from hay fever or other allergies.

Paullinia cupana syn. *P. sorbilis*
(Sapindaceae)

Guarana

Description Woody vine growing to a height of 33 ft (10 m). Has divided compound leaves, clusters of inconspicuous yellow flowers, and pear-shaped fruit that contains small shiny brown seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Guarana is native to tropical forests of the Brazilian Amazon, and is also cultivated in Brazil. The seeds are gathered when ripe.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents Guarana contains xanthine derivatives (including up to 7% caffeine, together with theobromine and theophylline), tannins, and saponins. The xanthines are stimulant and diuretic, and reduce fatigue over the short term.

History & Folklore In Brazil,

guarana is traditionally prepared by roasting, crushing, and drying the seeds. The resulting "cakes" are made into a tea, which is taken to counter fatigue or to treat diarrhea. Guarana has recently

become a popular alternative to coffee.



Seeds

Medicinal Actions & Uses Guarana's medicinal uses are similar to those of coffee (*Coffea arabica*, p. 192)—it is taken for headache and migraine, for mild depression, and to boost energy levels. The problems that apply to long-term or excessive consumption of coffee also apply to guarana—both stimulate over the short term but tend to inhibit the body's restorative processes over the longer term. In view of guarana's high tannin content, long-term use is even less advisable, because tannins impair the intestines' ability to absorb nutrients. Nevertheless, guarana is a useful short-term remedy for boosting energy, or for treating a tension headache that cannot be treated with rest. Guarana's astringency also treats chronic diarrhea.

Related Species *P. yoco*, native to the Colombian Amazon, is used by indigenous peoples to reduce fevers, as a stimulant, and as a post-malarial treatment.

Caution Do not take guarana if suffering from cardiovascular disease or from high blood pressure. It should also not be taken during pregnancy or while breastfeeding.

Pausinystalia yohimbe
syn. *Corynanthe yohimbe*
(Rubiaceae)

Yohimbe

Description Evergreen tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has reddish-brown bark, oblong or elliptical leaves, and clusters of small yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Yohimbe is native to the forests of western Africa, especially Cameroon, Zaïre, and Gabon. The bark is gathered at any time of year.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Yohimbe contains approximately 6% indole alkaloids (including yohimbine), pigments, and tannins. The alkaloids have a cerebral stimulant action at moderate doses, but are highly toxic in large doses.

History & Folklore Yohimbe has an ancient reputation in western Africa, especially among the Bantu people, as a male aphrodisiac and mild hallucinogen.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Yohimbe is little used in herbal medicine owing to its potential toxicity. In western Africa, it is often employed as a stimulant and as a means to counter erectile dysfunction. Yohimbine has been used in conventional medicine in the treatment of erectile dysfunction.

⚠ **Cautions** Take yohimbe only under professional supervision. The herb is subject to legal restrictions in many countries.

Peganum harmala
(Zygophyllaceae)

Harmala, African Rue

Description Multi-branched shrubby perennial growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has deeply cleft linear leaves, white 5-petaled flowers, and rounded 3-celled seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Middle East, North Africa, and southern Europe, harmala is naturalized in other subtropical regions, including Australia. It thrives in saline soil in semidesert areas. The seeds are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Seeds, root.

Constituents Harmala contains up to 4% indole alkaloids (including harmine, harmaline, and harmalol). Harmine has been used to help alleviate the tremors of Parkinsonism.



Harmala, which thrives in dry conditions, has been used as an intoxicant in the Middle East.

History & Folklore Since the earliest times, harmala has been used in the Middle East as a means to induce intoxication. Known to the Greek physicians Dioscorides (40–90 CE) and Galen (131–200 CE), as well as to their Arabic counterpart Avicenna (980–1037 CE), harmala was also used to expel intestinal worms and to promote the onset of menstrual flow.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Despite its long history as a euphoric and purportedly aphrodisiac herb, harmala is little used in contemporary Western herbal medicine because of its potential toxicity. The seeds have been taken, especially in the Middle East, to treat a very wide range of conditions, including high blood pressure, eye problems, psychiatric disorders, depression, Parkinson's disease, and cancer. In central Asia, the root is a popular medicinal remedy that is used to treat rheumatism and nervous conditions.

⚠ **Caution** This plant is toxic and should not be used under any circumstances.